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Sharon agrees to talks on cease-fire

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Nablus, said Israel "is showing it is willing to be flexible. We are waiting for the Palestinian side to show good will and to start fighting terror."

Zinni met yesterday with Arafat briefly, and with other top Palestinian officials at length, in Ramallah. He then met with Sharon at the Israeli leader's ranch in the Negev Desert.

The tentative signs of improvement in the Israeli-Palestinian situation came as consensus continued to build among Muslim leaders against any US strike against Iraq, and as Arab leaders pressed Vice President Dick Cheney, who is also touring the region, for more US pressure on Israel.

The Turkish prime minister, Bulent Ecevit, speaking at the European Union summit in Barcelona, yesterday joined Crown Prince Abdullah of Saudi Arabia and King Abdullah of Jordan, who had spoken out in opposition to military action against Iraq. The three US allies all border Iraq and fear Iraq could disintegrate under a US onslaught, destabilizing the region.



AP PHOTO

SAEB ERekat
Talk of results "premature"

Sporadic clashes continued in Israel and the Palestinian territories yesterday, but at a far lower level than in many weeks. Fighting was concentrated in and around Hebron, where Israeli and Palestinian extremists who reject each other's claims in the Holy Land have often spoiled cease-fire efforts in the past.

Israeli media reported that one Palestinian had been killed in Hebron while driving in an area of the city put under curfew by Israeli forces. The army denied any knowledge. Early today, three Palestinians, who Israelis said were attempting to plant an explosive device near the Netzarim checkpoint, were slain by Israeli troops.

In a development yesterday, two men convicted of collaborating with Israel were executed by Palestinian militiamen in Nablus. It was the third reported execution of collaborators in recent days. And it was the second time that Palestinian officials had said men had fallen into the hands of the militias because Israeli assaults on Palestinian Authority facilities had enabled them to escape from custody.

Despite the relative calm and the statement by Peres, Abu Sharif, the Arafat adviser, said Israel was continuing to launch attacks on the civilian quarters of Hebron and refugee camps in Bethlehem, and was ransacking villages in the Jenin area.

Saeb Erekat, the chief Palestinian negotiator, said: "It is premature to tell what the outcome" of the Zinni initiative "will be. General Zinni is not the Messiah, and the success of his mission depends on the honest and precise implementation by the Palestinians and Israelis" of plans for a cease-fire and eventual peace talks.

Abdullah Abu Hadid, leader of the al-Aqsa Brigades in Bethlehem, the group that launched a terror attack in Jerusalem's Beit Yisrael neighborhood two weeks ago, killing nine people as they emerged from synagogue, said yesterday that "we have declared a period of lull. We should give negotiation a chance."

He said the Brigades, which in recent weeks have eclipsed Hamas and Islamic Jihad among groups attacking Israel, said the organization does not have any plan to destroy Israel.

"We want to liberate our own land occupied in 1967," Hadid said as he walked through Bethlehem's Manger Square, escorted by armed guards. He said the Brigades attacking Israeli civilians "are avenging the crimes of Sharon against our people. . . . We want the Israelis to suffer as we suffer."

In Barcelona yesterday, European Union leaders reaffirmed their support for creation of a Palestinian state alongside an Israel secure, and within internationally recognized borders. This was consistent with statements from many Arab countries endorsing a Saudi Arabian proposal that the Arab world make peace and normalize relations with Israel in return for its complete withdrawal from lands occupied in the Six-Day War of 1967.

However, Syria, which initially withheld comment on the Saudi proposal then gave it lukewarm endorsement, called for participants in an upcoming Arab summit conference to take an uncompromising position with Israel.

After consultations between officials of Syria and Syria-dominated Lebanon, the prime ministers of the two countries said there could be no compromise on a United Nations resolution demanding Israeli withdrawal from occupied territories, including the Old City of Jerusalem and the right of Palestinian refugees to return to their land.

Israeli and Palestinian officials mutually acknowledge that there is no possibility of Israel surrendering authority over the Western Wall of the the biblical temple complex, where Israeli Jews were denied the right to pray until Israel captured the site, and no possibility that all Palestinians who claim descent from refugees of Israel's war of independence will be allowed to return.

Some Palestinian officials say they are prepared to negotiate on these points rather than insist on literal application of the UN resolutions.

Sa'id Ghazali of the Globe's Jerusalem bureau contributed to this report. Material from wire services also was used. Charles A. Radin can be reached by e-mail at radin@globe.com.

Late TV/Radio Listings

Following are television and radio program revisions for today, made since the Globe's TV Week went to press:

PANEL SHOWS

Fox News Sunday. Topics: The Pickering nomination is shot down — has bipartisanship left the Senate for good? Campaign finance reform battle in Congress; war on terrorism; has the government done everything possible to make America safe? Guests: Senators Don Nickles of Oklahoma, John McCain of Arizona, and John Breaux of Louisiana. 9 a.m. (11-25)

Meet the Press. Topics: US-Russian relations; the war on terrorism; nuclear weapons; and intelligence. Guests: Russian Defense Minister Sergei Ivanov. 10 a.m. (10), 10:30 a.m. (7).

Face the Nation. Topics: Senate agenda; judicial nominations; war on terrorism; and the Mideast. Guests: Senators Thomas A. Daschle of South Dakota and Orrin Hatch of Utah. Host: Bob Schieffer. 10:30 a.m. (4-12).

This Week With Sam & Cokie. Guests: the Rev. Christopher Coyne, Boston Archdiocese spokesman; the Rev. D. George Spagnolia, accused priest; Eileen Donoghue, attorney for Spagnolia; Stanley Brand, outside counsel to Arthur Andersen; Richard Perle, chairman, Defense Policy Board. Panel: Sam Donaldson, George Will, Cokie Roberts, George Stephanopoulos (ABC News). 11 a.m. (5-6-9).

CNN's Late Edition. Topics: Intelligence in the war on terrorism; Mideast violence; Enron-Arthur Andersen. Guests: Republican Senators Bob Graham of Florida and Richard Shelby of Alabama; chief Palestinian negotiator Saeb Erekat; Dore Gold, special adviser to Ariel Sharon; former prosecutor Cynthia Alksne; defense attorney Roy Black; former CIA director James Woolsey; former NATO Supreme Commander General George Joulwan. Host: Wolf Blitzer. Noon, (7).

Urban Update. Topics: Strategies on how to bridge the digital divide among black communities and a discussion with successful black technological leaders. Guests: Em Sanderson, founder and CEO of Inner-City Software; Tyrone Taborn, CEO of Career Communications Group; Al Zollar, general manager of Lotus Software. Host: Byron Barnett. Noon, (7).

CityLine. Topics: The Codman Square Health Center; raising awareness about a rare children's disorder called Kawasaki Disease. Guests: Alfred Smith; Bill Wajcerak; Jane Newberger; Gregory Chin. 12:30 p.m. (8).

60 Minutes. Topics: Interview with John Nash, whose life inspired the movie "A Beautiful Mind"; the government is still years away from constructing secure vessels and storage facilities for 90 million gallons of liquid nuclear waste — some of which is leaking — despite having already spent billions of dollars on the effort; a profile of Academy Award winner Judi Dench. 7 p.m. (4-12).

RADIO TODAY

Common Ground. Host: Anne Cody. WZLX-FM (100.7) 7-9 a.m.

Boston Sunday Review. Host: Mat Schaffer. WBCN-FM (104.1) 7-9 a.m.

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